The Guardian

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# ‘It’s a bit too castle-y’: plans to turn Cumbrian fortress into eco-attraction

## Level 3: Advanced

## 1 Warmer

**a. Which holiday destination would you most like to visit? Why? What would you like to do there?**

- Thailand
- Costa Rica
- Tanzania
- Australia
- Brazil

## 2 Key words

**a. Fill the gaps in the sentences using these key words from the text.**

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| boundary | carbon-zero | creepiness | custodian | drag show |
| ecotourism | fortress | geothermal | heir | hide-and-seek |
| isolated | obstacle | renewable | sanctuary | sustainable |

1. A strong, protected building used for defending a place is a _____.
2. Something that does not add carbon into the atmosphere has a _____ effect on the environment.
3. A type of energy that replaces itself naturally is _____. It is never completely used up.
4. When people or companies use methods that do not harm the environment, they are using _____ practices.
5. A place that is very far away from other places and may be difficult to get to is _____.
6. A person who is responsible for taking care of something valuable, such as property, money, or artwork is a _____.
7. A person who will receive money, property, or a title after someone else dies is an _____.
8. A performance given by men who wear women’s clothing as entertainers is called a _____.

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9. An object you must remove or go around in order to move forward is an _____.
10. Something connected to the natural heat deep underground is _____.
11. Something that is unpleasant and makes you feel nervous or frightened has a _____ to it.
12. A protected place that is safe for certain people or animals is a _____.
13. A children’s game in which one person looks for the others is called _____.
14. A line or mark on a map to show where one area of land ends and another begins is a _____.
15. A kind of travel business where the activities and trips cause little damage to the environment and often give people a chance to learn about nature is called _____.

**b. Use some of the key words above to complete the sentences.**

1. The company showed its commitment to the environment through its _____ policies and practices.
2. Last weekend, my friends and I did an _____ course in the woods. It was fun but tiring!
3. He really didn’t like to be around people and decided to move to an _____ place where he could be alone.
4. The old house had been empty for a long time, and there was a _____ to it, especially at night.
5. We booked our next holiday with an _____ company. We’re going to visit Costa Rica and see waterfalls, beaches, and lots of animals in the wild.

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***Young ‘custodian’ hopes to make ancestral home of Muncaster first carbon-zero castle in UK***

**Helen Pidd**

**26 February, 2023**

1 In 1990, the year Ewan Frost-Pennington was born, the final bears left Muncaster Castle in the Lake District in northwest England. Winnie, a black bear, departed Cumbria for Dudley Zoo, along with Inca, her daughter, and her sister, Gretel.

2 Three decades later, the bear pit has now been covered over with a solar farm. It was Frost-Pennington’s idea. He is the heir to the 800-year-old pink granite fortress, and he is trying to make Muncaster the first carbon-zero castle in the UK.

3 In early 2022, the 32-year-old was living in San Francisco and working as a renewable energy consultant. Now he is earning 25 per cent of his salary and is living in a 14th-century tower with a secret passage, surrounded by his grandparents’ old furniture.

4 His new job running Muncaster is to figure out a way to make the 800-hectare (2,000-acre) estate not just sustainable but also attractive to a younger audience.

5 Its isolated location, an hour off the M6 motorway and two hours from Manchester Airport, can make it difficult to attract foreign tourists. Frost-Pennington – who prefers the term ‘custodian’ to ‘heir’ – must be creative. In April, he will be hosting Muncaster’s first drag show, Dragcaster, as well as bringing back its Sausage Fest.

6 This summer will see the return of Krankenhaus, a music festival, and Race the Tide, a 10km obstacle race along – and in – the tidal River Esk.

7 Living in a remote castle with his parents has its challenges for a young, single man (his US girlfriend who came with him from California did not stay). “To be honest, I’m finding it a bit too castle-y,” he said, giving the *Guardian* a tour in February. “It’s like I’m wearing the clothes of my ancestors. It feels a bit itchy.”

8 The castle’s Grade-I listing means he cannot put up his own pictures and it is freezing most of the time. The solar panels and geothermal heat pump mean that at least 60% of the building’s energy use is zero carbon, but Frost-Pennington’s parents insist they only heat the rooms the public use. The family like to claim it is Britain’s most haunted castle – they get their biggest audience around Halloween, for an event they call Scarecaster – and there is a definite creepiness, with child dolls behind corners and dusty cabinets of toy soldiers.

9 Out of his bedroom window, Frost-Pennington can see the hills of Eskdale, with Scafell Pike, England’s highest mountain, lurking in the distance. The Victorian art critic John Ruskin described the view from Muncaster as “the gateway to paradise”. But Frost-Pennington is just as keen to point out the 0.8-mile (1.3km) hole he had dug to make way for the castle’s heat pump.

10 Before Frost-Pennington decided to return, his younger sister, Isla, ran Muncaster. She quit after falling in love with a farmer from Lancashire, an hour and a half away. Their brother, Fraser, was in the armed forces and now works for a company focused on reducing waste.

11 Built to keep out the Scots, Muncaster Castle has been in the family for at least 800 years. Frost-Pennington’s mother, Iona, took over aged 23. Her parents and grandparents literally sold the family silver and most of the original 12,000-hectare estate to keep the castle.

12 Growing up in a castle with 31 hectares of gardens and its own owl sanctuary could be fun. Hide-and-seek games were amazing, though “you’d never find anyone” without clear boundaries, says Frost-Pennington.

13 Sometimes the tourism business makes less than £10,000 of annual profit. Iona Frost-Pennington, who recently painted the huge drawing room herself, pays herself just £3,000 a year.

14 Her son Ewan learned at a young age not to tell other children where he lived – “otherwise you become Castle Boy”. He has now accepted his role. “There is no way of saying ‘I live in a castle’ without sounding like an idiot,” he said. For his own ego, he wants to prove he can increase visitor numbers through ecotourism.

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15 Though he will one day inherit the castle, Iona has yet to allow her elder son to touch the family’s most valuable possession. In the 1460s, one of their ancestors offered sanctuary to Henry VI as the monarch fled from defeat in the War of the Roses. Henry left a Venetian glass bowl as a thank-you gift along with a prediction that as long as the bowl remains, the Penningtons will remain at Muncaster.

16 Waving the *Guardian* goodbye, Frost-Pennington says he is looking forward to the article: “I just hope it doesn’t turn out to be a story of the son who ruined everything.”

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## 3 Comprehension check

**a. Answer the questions using information from the article.**

1. Where is Muncaster Castle?
2. Who are Winnie, Inca, and Gretel?
3. What is the bear area now?
4. How old is the castle?
5. What is Frost-Pennington trying to do at Muncaster Castle?
6. What is one of the events Muncaster is hosting in 2023?
7. How does Muncaster get its energy?
8. How many brothers and sisters does Ewan Frost-Pennington have?
9. How much does Muncaster’s tourism business make in a year?
10. What is the family’s most valuable possession?

## 4 Key language

**a. Match the words in the left-hand column with those in the right-hand column to make phrases from the text.**

| | |
|---|---|
| 1. most valuable | a. boundaries |
| 2. hide-and-seek | b. castle |
| 3. clear | c. energy |
| 4. thank-you | d. games |
| 5. remote | e. location |
| 6. renewable | f. passage |
| 7. isolated | g. possession |
| 8. secret | h. gift |

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## 5 Discussion

**a. Discuss these statements.**

- “Ecotourism is better than regular tourism because it protects the environment.”
- “All buildings should use renewable energy sources.”
- “It is important to keep land and possessions in the family.”

## 6 In your own words

**a. Search online to find more information about ecotourism. Find some top locations for ecotourism holidays and what you can do in those places. Work in small groups and organise a trip to that place, including what you would do there.**

**b. Report your ideas to the class.**

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